

School Committee of the Whole - Notes - Monday, June 15, 2020 - 4 PM -
Via Zoom

Mayor - called meeting to order at 4:03 PM

Roll Call - 7-0

Salute the Flag

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Ms. Patterson will be with us shortly - This budget challenge that we are currently in, has taken tremendous amount of work and we've had to make a number of decisions - we still have a little bit of work to do - we aren't fully there as yet - Tried to be very thoughtful in our decisions

Ms. Patterson - We are still identifying areas - staying as far away from classroom teachers as possible. We have identified (4) Administrators that will be reduced or won't be replaced. We are still looking at \$500,000 to get us to level funding. We are working on additional places to cut, trying to look in every category possible - there are already significant deductions, district wide, MHS positions that aren't going to be refilled, so those are reductions, duplications of paras so those have been broken out - Middle School environment teachers, EL although we had a retirement, another EL teacher has to be included - some reductions in Special Ed - trying to pay out of district tuitions ahead of time, IEP counts are hard to figure - Voke - substantial saving of \$100,000 from out of district + other departments have been reduced. Guidance - pretty lean - some positions aren't cut, but just not refilling - ELA - had some significant reductions here - Same with Social Studies - Math - Envisions Program is set to renew, so we didn't cut it - Science - in year 2 for Foss system, a 3 year plan - World Language - consolidated, lost Casit funding source - Arts - we reduced as much as we could. In Phys Ed/Health we reduced supplies and maintenance - Library/Media - peeling back in this department, with infusion of chromebooks, minimized need for tech upgrades, plusCares Act to purchase additional devices - Nurses - can't reduce much here, through the city, we will pre purchase the PPE and cleaning equipment for first 3 months of school year - via FEMA & Cares Act - Athletics - we reduced again, not knowing if we will have a full fall athletic program - Student Activities - basically are stipends for advisory teachers - Security - reduced this again - Building & Grounds - assisted budget by pre purchasing - Still have to worry about the utilities, even though schools have been closed, no real cuts in bills - It's been an exhaustive process to try to not affect student learning - I don't have better news, but these are dire times.

Member Van der Kloot - Great deal of information for us to receive now, and some not clear to me - Mentioned out of district, vocational ? - Are the students not going to Essex and Minuteman? Or were numbers inflated as you thought other students were going out of the district?

Ms. Patterson - Correct. Only 2 were going to out of district, so we saved \$100,000

Member Van der Kloot - Guidance position?

Ms. Patterson - It was determined that it was not needed

Member Van der Kloot - are we down one guidance counselor

Ms. Patterson - not necessarily

Member Van der Kloot - We are down a position in Science? Enrollment or consolidation

Ms. Patterson - High school consolidation

Member Van der Kloot - has there been a cut in Library staff?

Ms. Patterson - currently being reviewed

Member Van der Kloot - With special education and the pre payment of tuition, so does that mean our end of the year budget will come balanced?

Ms. Patterson - that is our goal - not as many encumbrances in - slight bubble in FY 20 circuit breaker - only 3 months of tuition

Ms. Patterson - Out of district

Member Van der Kloot - any savings utilities since no school?

Ms. Patterson - No significant change in utility bills

Member Van der Kloot - Layoffs & Retirements on front sheet - do you still have the cola's and steps are they included?

Ms. Patterson - so those being laid off or retiring - they won't get raises - reducing a salary - so it's a net savings, not completely gone

Member Ruseau - "Blood from a stone" - when will SC know about the \$500,000 as I don't want to hear that for the first time at the public meeting on June 29th

Ms. Patterson - it was my goal was to have budget books, well before the public hearing - but we are still identifying items.

Mayor - With so many unknowns, are you going to do a bound book for the SC budget? Maybe hold off until we have the state aid numbers in July? I'd hate for you to make up two bound books ...

Ms. Patterson - original timeline is June 30th - and the body has to approve it - binders are really just for SC and administration - and full document is shared with units and City Council- I don't have the luxury to wait until July

Member Graham - at what point will we get a narrative as to what these cuts will look like - no one has painted what our schools will look like in July - we are just tap dancing around it - when are we getting a real budget, because I'm not voting on a budget until I know that ...

Ms. Patterson - well with unions, we are trying to consolidate and be resourceful - we don't want to cut staffing, trying to get there in other capacities - Ch 70 could come in higher? I can't build a budget on assumptions - so we use the level fund figure as the final breaking point - we've been cutting resources, paying as much as we can, timing of close outs, trying the best we can

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - we have tried to stay as far away from the classrooms as possible, as we look at other areas, or areas of redundancy - we are increasing other employees job responsibilities and not wanting to end up cutting in the wrong spots - looking to streamline - yet there are areas we can not touch - although we said we would take cuts evenly across the board, that's not feasible - Nursing for example, we will not touch, as we'll need every nurse we have - so some of the discussions, we know we need to cut, but there are some areas we have to hold because it's an incredibly essential function - Didn't touch areas of cleaning, as we realize we will need to clean on a more frequent basis - we need to keep sanitizing - reduces amount of areas you are able to cut - it's just a very difficult process and difficult balancing it and we just need a little more time, so we can thoughtful reductions as far away from the classrooms - based on IEPs are written we have to provide the proper number of paras - we still have a significant number to be creative with

Member Graham - we have squeezed too much - half a million dollars is not shaving supply office budgets - that's not going to work - I won't vote a budget on numbers, there are people behind those numbers. I'm not clear what we are supposed to do here. What is the day we will be able to do that? There are 150 people on this call, so I think they want to know what school will look like in the fall

Mayor - we are hoping for more info from the state but it probably won't happen until July or August...including our state aid number - We might get cut from \$29M state aid - but we may not. We just have no way of knowing

Member Graham - not sure why we are having a public budget hearing on June 29th - we should probably revisit this timeline - we can't decide on next year, because we can't plan without a budget - today's the last day of school and I don't see what information we have right now - I know it's an impossible situation

Member Ruseau - who is finding the money and who is doing the prep for the fall?

Mayor - we need to focus on getting back to school, but do we have a meeting on the 29th or do we postpone it?

Member McLaughlin - when is Ms. Patterson last day? And did we hire someone else?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - That will be discussed in the executive session.

Member Van der Kloot - The problem for us as the school committee is we don't have an understanding of how it will impact the school community

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - We hope to be able to respond to some of the questions in more detail in executive session

Member Van der Kloot - we have retirements every year, but we'd like to be able to recognize those that are retiring as we annually do

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - yes, we'd like to recognize all of their years of service

Mayor - we had discussed librarians, art teachers and physical education teachers - can you go over the athletic and security cuts?

Ms. Patterson - Athletics - we made cuts in equipment and - not sure where fall sports will be as yet, so coaches salaries could be discussed - security - replacement of different cameras, completed an upgrade of entire raptor system - all new units with money from the safety grant that was approved by schools and capital monies, we were able to cut security down to bear minimum

Mayor - thank you

Member Van der Kloot - I think the budget hearing on the 29th, should be used as a placeholder - it might not be the right date, so we should have other options

Member Graham - we have to publicize this meeting 2 weeks ahead of time?

Mayor - Yes

Member Van der Kloot - Let's post it for now

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - That is the date that we proposed in order to have a 2 week posting window - but we would reschedule if body chooses to do that

Member Ruseau - if no budget is passed by June 30th are we legally allowed to pay people in July?

Ms. Patterson - Yes, bills could be paid in July, per the state

Member Van der Kloot - we are going to have to really look and understand this budget while Ms. Patterson is still with us. It is a budget fraught with difficulty...

Member Ruseau - I want to know what a reduction looks like so for example if a supply list is cut, will teachers have to buy supplies or parents? That is the type of narrative I am looking for. I want to know the story behind the cuts, not just the dollars.

Member Kreatz - what would happen if the budget is not ready for council on June 30th? Do we go to a 1/12

Mayor - Council wants to start review the city side budget on June 20th

Ms. Patterson - it boils down to what the appropriation will be

July 13, 2020

Member Van der Kloot - here we have a school budget cut to the bones - Mayor, I know we have a rainy day fund, could the schools use some of it for the schools?

Mayor - Yes - we do plan to use half of it for city and half for schools, but we will not know that figure until final state aid budget in July

Member Van der Kloot - tough day for those receiving pink slips today - they are very valued to us - we want to keep them - it's important to say we will do our very best to bring back as many of our teachers as possible - there is some hope for some people

Mayor - city taking 50% of the rainy day fund - as long as Local Aid, Chapter 70 monies are in tack

Mayor - any other questions?

Member Graham - motion to adjourn, seconded by Member Kreatz

Roll Call Vote 7-0

Meeting adjourned - 5:14 PM